

LIVE WELL

Whether you're after a healthy mind, bank balance or relationships, we've got all your wellbeing needs covered this month

IS IT TIME TO STOP SAYING WE'RE FINE?

Painting over how you truly feel can lead to frustration; here's how to let go of your expectations and lean into being vulnerable with your emotions ...♡

Hey, how are you?

I'm fine, thanks. How are you?

Fine yeah - just really busy!

Same here!



How many times do you think you've said 'I'm fine, thanks', this week? According to The Mental Health Foundation, a study of 2,000 people found that the average adult will say that exact phrase 14 times over the course of seven days, but, and here's the catch, only 19 percent of us actually mean it. So, what gives? Is there a reason why many of us prefer to hide behind the word 'fine', rather than tell people how we're actually holding up? Why does saying 'we're fine', feel so much more palatable than the truth? To understand why we use this phrase as an alternative to being real with our emotions, we consulted the experts.

Cracking the code

We often say we're fine when we're actually not, largely because we feel shame around feeling anything other than good," explains Jill Ritchie, an intuitive accredited life and business coach (jill-ritchie.com). "There's an expectation placed on us to push past life's struggles, to 'pull yourself together', to 'get on with it' and as a human being we want to fit in, so we do just that. This is hard-wired in our subconscious mind and it's possible we've witnessed our parents/caregivers/grandparents spin a lot of plates and cope under difficult circumstances, so in turn, we think we should be doing the same." If we've had a difficult day, sometimes offloading those emotions onto someone else can feel like we're passing on a burden. So how can we push past this and learn to be more transparent with what we're feeling?

Changing the narrative

"If you are saying you are 'fine' when you are far from it, your 'stiff upper lip' may be hindering your life connections, relationships and love," says emotional trauma expert Antonia Harman (divineempowerment.co.uk). "When you don't express feelings and boundaries, people don't know what you are going through, so how can they help you?" Often, we would rather say we are 'fine' than feel judged or invite more questions. The key to solving this? Some good-old-fashioned introspection. "If we can connect more to our own feelings and truth, then we worry far less

about being a burden to anyone," says Jill. "The relationship with the self is the most important relationship we can ever have. Right now, I invite you to pause for a few seconds, and tune into your own emotions. Ask yourself 'how am I really today?' Doing this helps you come out of your mind and feel your own feelings. Once we can be honest and hold space for our emotions, we get more comfortable sharing our truth with others. If you struggle with this, I invite you to imagine yourself as a small child, holding space for her/him without judgement. This is also known as inner-child work, and it helps heal trauma and shame."

Feel the feels

Of course, expressing our feelings to nearest and dearest is sometimes easier said than done. Talking to a qualified professional, such as a therapist or a counsellor, can help. "When you take responsibility for getting to know yourself, conversations become so much easier," says Jill. "Speak your truth; not honouring it can leave you feeling undervalued, unworthy, and unfulfilled. It's perfectly normal to feel a whole spectrum of emotions in one day. But if you can honour each one, without judgement, your emotions will wash through you far quicker than trying to suppress them." So, next time a friend checks in on you, perhaps it's time to ditch the word 'fine', and open up the conversation with 'I'm feeling' instead. **H&W**

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"Sometimes offloading those emotions can feel like we're passing on a burden"



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3 STEPS TO HAVING HONEST CONVERSATIONS

1. BE AWARE

Find yourself struggling to express your thoughts? Are the words on the tip of your tongue? It could be time to bring down the barriers and learn how to become more emotionally intuitive. "Tune into yourself and work on developing internal awareness," says Dr Elena Touroni, a consultant psychologist and co-founder of (thechelseapsychologyclinic.com). "You need to better understand yourself in order to be able to share how you feel with another person."

2. DON'T JUDGE

To cultivate conversations that feel emotionally-freeing, hold a zero-judgement space. "Be compassionate, towards yourself and others when sharing the important stuff, so no one feels judged, criticised or blamed when sharing," says Dr Touroni. This is key to building trust between you and the other person, so don't be too hasty to judge if you really want your relationships and friendships to go the mile.

3. REALLY LISTEN

Feel like your friend has something on their mind? Make sure you're really listening to what they're saying. Tune into body language and their tone of voice. If they're not making eye contact with you, they probably feel ashamed. If they're shuffling in their seat, they probably feel anxious. "Ask the other person questions about their life and try to dig deeper into their responses," says Dr Touroni. "Pay attention to what they're saying – and what they're not saying – about their life and situation."

